It's Fine; I'm Fine; Everything is Fine

By (Authors listed in footnoted sources)

NOTE: Inspired by the poetry compilation of Delaney Holliday of Bellevue West High School of Illinois and the IHSA Speech 2020 State Champion.

When people ask me how I'm doing . . .

I want to say,

My depression is an angry deity, a jealous god

a thirsty shadow that wrings my joy like a dishrag

and makes juice out of my smile

I want to say,

This sadness is the only clean shirt I have left

and my washing machine has been broken for months,

[But instead]

I laugh and I say,

"I'm doing alright." **(1)**

[and]

4NG Fanatics

I constantly wonder what happens to a girl who is too anxious to ever feel like magic. Can she still fly with wings that tremble? **(2)**

******

Anxiety is desperately trying

To look strong when you're undeniably weak

"I'm calm, I'm in control"

"I can do this" . . . No, no, no

Breathe, breathe . . .

Every day you have a choice

Walk out of the house

Leaving your agitation by the door

Or collapse, curl up in a corner. **(3)**

******

Things I would Like to Tell Every Teen-age Girl. . .

the world is trying to kill you.

and if you do not hold each other up, no one else will. **(4)**

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

INTRODUCTION

According to the National Institutes of Health nearly 33 percent of teenagers will experience an anxiety disorder, and hospital admissions for suicidal teenagers have doubled over the past decade. Why?

Today we live in a world that feels chaotic and threatening: Not only have we seen an increase in school shootings, the very fabric of our lives has been disrupted by pandemics, racial protests and a divisive political climate. Not to mention . . . the rise of social media. Multiple studies have found a link between social media and an increased risk for depression, anxiety, and even suicidal thoughts.

But . . . It's Fine; I'm Fine; Everything is Fine - a poetry program by Rudy Francisco, Jae Nichelle, Zeina El-Hoss, Melissa Newman-Evans, Rupi Kuar, Reagan Myers, and Patrick Roche

I do not want to have you

To fill the empty parts of me.

I want to be full on my own

I want to be so complete

I could light a whole city . . . [because] If you are not enough for yourself. You will never be enough for someone else. **(5)**

******

FOR EDUCATIONAL

4NG Fanatics

So my anxiety and I have inside jokes. Like when I say: "I'ma go talk to that person over there", my anxiety looks at me and is like: "Bitch . . . please." Because of her, I don't correct people at restaurants who get my order wrong. I just eat it. Because you know, maybe sweet potato fries are what I wanted but the broccoli you gave me is what I needed, thank you. **(2)**

******

Depression is a silent film, a monologue shot underwater, depression is sulking because I won't talk to it anymore, by which I mean ABOUT it. There are some days I am so sad I don't remember what it's like not to be, like when you have a bad cold and you forget how to breathe through your nose and you're so sure you'll never breathe through your nose again and I'm so sure I'll never feel joy again.

Except when you have a cold you can call in sick to work, and people tell you to get well soon, and there is a whole soup genre dedicated your well-being. I can't call in "sad" to work.

So sometimes all I can do is laugh, if I don't, there might be nothing left.

This week I sat in an auto zone parking lot and cried for ten minutes because I couldn't change a head light,
My headlight went out and my first thought was "seems right." I couldn't change it myself because I'd have to take off the whole bumper or something and I thought "of course" or "I wish I was dead."

Being this kind of sad is funny that way, no inconvenience is a minor inconvenience, it's all the end of the world or might as well be, my brain is dramatic like that. **(6)**

******

When People Ask Me How I'm Doing
I want to say,
Getting out of bed has become a magic trick.
I am probably the worst magician I know.
But I'd rather not ruin someone's day with my tragic honesty
so instead I treat my face like a pumpkin.

4NG Fanatics

I pretend that it's Halloween
I carve it into something acceptable.
When people ask me how I'm doing, **(1)**
It is better to stay silent. . .

******

This is a call to arms, a call to speak
This is not family gatherings when I mention mental health
And am told not to spoil the turkey
That it is uncouth
Impolite
This is taking that silence and breaking it with my hands
With my teeth and tongue
This is banging our heads against the walls
Not out of insanity
But to try to make some noise
To be heard
This is not a sign of weakness
This is saying that we're fighting and we've been fighting with every weapon and fist we have
We've crashed against the cliffside

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Broken and splintered
But we're still fighting with whatever we can
I'm using my voice
That's all I have left **(7)**

******

My anxiety and I have learned to live together. As I speak, I am pushing against her weight on my shoulders and that is why I shake. Sometimes I have to fight to stand up straight. Stop rocking. I have been fighting her for control of our house for years. Fighting not to crack. Stop rocking, don't shake, breathe. **(6)**

*****

I don't know what living a balanced life feels like. When I am sad, i don't cry i pour. When i am happy, i don't smile i glow. when i am angry, i don't yell i burn. . I don't grieve. I shatter. **(5)**

[But, you know] When the world comes crashing at your feet, it's okay to let others help pick up the pieces.
If we're present to take part in your happiness . . . we are more than capable of sharing your pain. **(8)**

4NG Fanatics

[After all] What is stronger than the human heart which shatters over and over and still lives . . . **(5)**

*****

Things I would Like to Tell Every Teen-age Girl . . . the world is trying to kill you. It is trying to do this by stealing your voice. You'll never deserve it. Telling you to be ready is pointless. Telling you to prepare yourself is just another way to blame you when it happens.

The world is trying to kill each and every one of you and if you do not hold each other up, no one else will. **(4)**

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

SOURCES

(1) ***Author: Rudy Francisco***
Poem Title: When People Ask Me How I'm Doing
Book: Helium
ISBN: 978-1943735198
Publisher: Button Poetry
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2017

(2) ***Author: Jae Nichelle***
Poem Title: Friends with Benefits
Book: She Healed
ISBN: 978-1073398362
Publisher: Independently Published
Date (Month/Year): June 2019

(3) ***Author: Zeina El-Hoss***
Poem Title: A Poem on What Anxiety Really Is
Website: https://themighty.com/2017/04/poetry-what-anxiety-is/
Publisher: TheMighty.com – NSDA Approved Website
Date (Month/Year): April 24, 2017

(4) ***Author: Melissa Newman-Evans***
Poem Title: Thing I Would Like to Tell Every Teen-age Girl
Website: https://medium.com/poem-of-the-day/melissa-newman-evans-nine-things-i-would-like-to-tell-to-every-teenage-girl-f4e76cfdaabb
Publisher: Medium.com – NSDA Approved Website
Date (Month/Year): March 7, 2019

(5) ***Author: Rupi Kaur***
Book: Milk and Honey
ISBN: 978-1449474256
Publisher: Andrews McMeel Publishing
Date (Month/Year): October 2015

(6) ***Author: Reagan Myers***
Poem Title: Depression is Funny Like That
Website: https://medium.com/@ChloeEJackson/6-spoken-word-videos-to-help-with-your-depression-9937e7145773
Publisher: Medium.com – NSDA Approved Website (Video Only)
Text of Selection can be found at
https://www.poemhunter.com/poem/depression-is-funny-like-that-by-reagan-myers/
Date (Month/Year): July 15, 2019

(7) ***Author: Patrick Roche***
Poem Title: Every 40 Seconds
Website: https://themighty.com/2019/06/slam-poetry-mental-illness/
Publisher: The Mighty.com – NSDA Approved Website (Video Only)
Text of Selection can be found at
https://genius.com/Patrick-roche-every-forty-seconds-annotated
Date (Month/Year): June 27, 2019

(8) ***Author: Rupi Kaur***
Book: The Sun and Her Flowers
ISBN: 978-1449486792
Publisher: Andrews McMeel Publishing
Date (Month/Year): October 2017

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY